The Kentucky Cycle

By Robert Schenkkan

Characters: Star (30s) a Cherokee woman kidnapped by Michael Rowen with the express purpose of providing him with an heir, and Patrick (16) their son.
Scene: The Rowen homestead in Eastern Kentucky, 1792

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Sixteen years before, Star was taken captive from her tribe by the brutal Michael Rowen, who severed the tendon in her heel so she couldn't run away. She has since resigned herself to life with the arrogant man.*

ACTRESS: *Their son, Patrick, has fallen in love with a girl on a neighboring farm, and here asks his mother for help in courting her.*

TOGETHER: *The Kentucky Cycle by Robert Schenkkan.*

(Dusk. The front yard of the Rowen house. The original single room has been expanded. Among other additions is a simple front porch and steps. The house and yard are bare and unadorned, strictly functional. There is a pile of logs on the porch and an old axe. In the yard is a tin tub, partially filled with water. Patrick enters, cradling his rifle and a leather bag containing a pair of dead rabbits. Star limps in, carrying two wooden buckets full of water. She stops and looks at Patrick.)

STAR: Ostas hindhalid? [Good hunting?]

PATRICK: Couple of rabbits. Here, gimme those, Ma. (He throws his bag on the porch, lays his rifle down and takes the buckets from her. He pours them into the tub.)

STAR: To hi ju? [How are you?]

PATRICK: I'm fine.

STAR: It embarrasses you now to speak the language of your grandfathers?

PATRICK: No. It don't embarrass me. I just don't see the point.

STAR: Not to forget who you are, that is the point.

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PATRICK: Not much danger of that around here, is there? (Beat.)

STAR: I'll bring your supper out. Cooler on the porch. (He sits. She goes in, returns with a bowl of food. She picks up the rabbits while he eats.)

PATRICK: Good.

STAR: Took you all day to get these? Losin' your touch.

PATRICK: Didn't take me all... (Before he can finish protesting, Star goes inside with the rabbits. She returns.) Most of the mornin' I sat up on the ridge.

STAR: Oh. Corn gonna plant itself this year?

PATRICK: I finished that piece on the Shilling.

STAR: Uh-huh. What's on the ridge worth a visit?

PATRICK: Nothin'. Just did me some thinkin'.

STAR: Alone? (Beat.)

PATRICK: Mostly.

STAR: I knew when that Talbert girl come sniffin' round here this morn in' you wasn't gonna get a lick of work done.

PATRICK: I planted the damn field!

STAR: Don't curse in front of your ma.

PATRICK: Don't see what you got against the Talberts. From what I hear you're a regular visitor over there. (Beat.)

STAR: What is it you hear?

PATRICK: You doctored her Pa.

STAR: His name is Joseph.

PATRICK: Joseph? Michael know about it?

STAR: What do you think?

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PATRICK: I think he hears about it, he'll skin you alive.

STAR: Are you gonna tell him? (Beat.) Folks think I have the Gift for healin' and readin' dreams. Because I'm different. Because I'm Cherokee. Michael laughs, but as long as they pay, he laughs to himself. I think, why should he have all this money? Why not my son? And so, when I can, I see people secretly. Like Joseph.

PATRICK: For me?

STAR: Someday you'll want land of your own. A woman of your own.

PATRICK: Why hide it from me?

STAR: So if Michael finds out, he'll be angry only with me. (Beat. He crosses over and hugs her knees, puts his head in her lap.)

PATRICK: Do yu jiskanoqi. Skidoliga? [I am sorry. Forgive me?] (She kisses him on the top of his head, strokes his hair roughly.)

STAR: I gvkewidina. [It is forgotten.] You want this Ruth Talbert?

PATRICK: Rebecca.

STAR: Whatever. What she wants, you can give her easy enough. You don't have to marry her for that.

PATRICK: She ain't like that.

STAR: I see. Maybe she's smarter than I thought.

PATRICK: I love her.

STAR: You love her. Now. Today, you love her. But tomorrow? Next year? Chuji. Why so much hurry? Why marry her? (Beat.)

PATRICK: If I marry her, maybe her pa'd gimme that piece of bottom land next to ours. (She cuffs him.)

STAR: You are your father's son. Truly.

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PATRICK: Not so's he'd notice.

STAR: I never understand this. What you two have is never enough. You work from sunrise to sunset and you can't plow all what you have now, but you want more. More land! Why?

PATRICK: It's the only thing that lasts. (Beat.)

STAR: You live like that, Chuji, you live a lonely life.

PATRICK: Somethin' different.

STAR: Everybody gotta right to some happiness, osta Chuji. You gotta right.

PATRICK: She makes me happy. Rebecca. (Beat.) You help me?

STAR: How?

PATRICK: Talk to him for me. 'Bout us. (She walks to the tub, runs her hand through the water.)

STAR: Michael don't listen to me.

PATRICK: He's comin' back. (She hesitates.)

STAR: You seen him?

PATRICK: This morn in' .

STAR: You sure?

PATRICK: Somebody was movin' thru the gap in a hurry.

STAR: Coulda been anybody.

PATRICK: Who?

STAR: When'lI he get here?

PATRICK: Tonight mebbe. Tomorrow for sure. But tonight I think.(Beat.) You could tell him... tell him that Talbert bottom land'd give us a third agin as much.

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STAR: It'd give your pa a third agin as much. (She takes his bowl and starts into the house.)

PATRICK: Same thing. It's all gonna come down to me, innit?

STAR: Is it? (She sits on the porch. Patrick stares at her in confusion.)

PATRICK: What're you talkin' 'bout? **STAR:** I'm not sayin' nothin'. Said too much already. (Preoccupied, she absentmindedly strokes her injured leg.)

PATRICK: Your leg botherin' you a lot? (She shrugs. Looks off into the woods where Michael is.) Here. Lemme rub it for you. (He sits next to her. She hikes up her skirt and swings her leg into his lap. He begins to knead her scarred calf She leans back against a post, her eyes closed.) What'd you mean about... about the land not comin' to me. I'm his only son.

STAR: Are you?

PATRICK: What d'you mean, "Are you?" -"Is it?" You know somethin' why don't you just say it, 'stead of dancin' around!

STAR: Lower.

PATRICK: What?

STAR: Rub lower. (He does so.) What does Michael do in Louisville?

PATRICK: I don't know.

STAR: Home come?

PATRICK: 'Cause I ain't never been.

STAR: How come?

PATRICK: 'Cause I gotta stay here and take care of things! (Beat.) **STAR:** He got a woman down there.

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PATRICK: How do you know?

STAR: I seen her in a dream.

PATRICK: You seen her?

STAR: Blue eyes, corn-silk hair. She always be crossin' a muddy river in my dreams.

PATRICK: Muddy water? That's death. (She nods.) Mebbe she's dead already.

STAR: Mebbe.

PATRICK: What I care if he got some woman down there? Specially if she's dead. now.

STAR: Mebbe she had him a baby.

PATRICK: He... got him another family down there?

STAR: Why else he always got to go alone? You a growned man, Chuji. With your help, he could pack in twice as much on these trips. You ever knowed Michael to turn his back on a dollar? How come he don't take you?

PATRICK: You seen the baby in your dream?

STAR: Clear as the bottom of the Shillin'.

PATRICK: Boy or girl?

STAR: She give him a son.

PATRICK: A son!

STAR: Where does that leave you?

PATRICK: I'd still be the oldest! It'd all still come to me! That's the law!

STAR: Law? (She laughs.) Michael ever pay a whole lotta mind to the law?

PATRICK: Why wouldn't he let me have my share?

STAR: You know why.

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PATRICK: Why!

STAR: 'Cause he hates you.

PATRICK: That's a lie!

STAR: Look me in the face and tell me it is! (He can't.)

PATRICK: Why? Why's he hate me? Nothin' I ever do is right. Never has been. He looks at me like I was some kinda mad dog, gonna tear somethin' precious away from him.

STAR: He's afraid of you.

PATRICK: Afraid?! Hell, Michael Rowen ain't afraid of nothin'!

STAR: Look at yourself, Chuji, look! See yourself as you really are not like that hungry dog he turns you into, the one who whines and licks the hand that beats him. You are bigger than him now. And stronger. He sees you and he feels old. He feels tired. He sees death in you. That's how you scare him, Chuji, and that's why he hates you. Because there is no forgiving that. And that's why he will never give you your rightful share of this land. Your land. Not till you bury him innit! (Beat.) Ask him. You don't believe me? Ask him for your share and see what he says.

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AWARD HISTORY

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